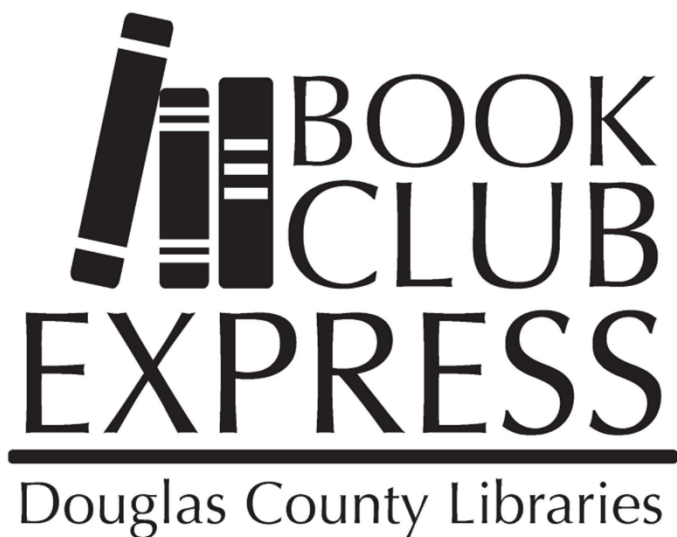




The Women
by Kristin Hannah

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Discussion Questions

1. “Women can be heroes.” Frankie believes her future as a wife and mother is set in stone until Rye says this. It is a small comment that tears a big hole in Frankie’s perception of the world. These words, and her brother’s enlistment, inspire Frankie to join the Army Nurse Corps. It is a decision founded on the patriotism of the post-World War II era and her family’s proud history of service.

Why do you think Frankie’s parents were so appalled by her enlistment in the Army? Was it simply her sex? Or was there more to it? Discuss how the “conformity” of the 1950s caged women and the “freedom” of the 1960s changed the perception of where women “belong.” How do you think Bette and Connor’s own family history of service impacted their opinion of her choice?

2. Frankie arrives in Vietnam filled with idealism and hope. She wants to “make a difference.” But almost instantly, she is thrust into the truth of war: the trauma, the heartbreak, the fear. She thinks that she is too inexperienced and that she has made a mistake. It is Ethel who talks her through this and gives her comfort. How does this friendship change and grow over time? How do Ethel and Barb change Frankie’s view of the world?

3. Throughout the novel, characters listen to the pop music of the 1960s by such bands as The Beatles, The Doors, Creedence Clearwater Revival and Cream. Classic Rock is now more than 50 years old, and artists from that era continue to tour and sell out arenas. Why do you think the 1960s music that reflected the counterculture and changing mores continues to appeal to so many generations of fans? Are the lyrics of these songs and the stories they tell still relevant in the 21st century? Are you a fan of Classic Rock? Which songs? Which artists? What do they mean to you and why?

4. During her Tour of Duty, Frankie evolves from sheltered young woman into hardened combat nurse. As wounded flood into the hospital, she begins to question the American government’s involvement in the war. She sees the truth behind the lies that are being told in the media and at home. The Vietnam generation was fueled by dreams and lost on the battlefield. Discuss how the political climate changed the war and how disillusionment with the government changed Americans’ minds.

5. In Vietnam, Frankie saves lives. During her service, she is aware of the protests going on “back in the world”: the flag burnings and the sit-ins and the marches. She wonders why people can’t oppose the war but support the soldiers. Even so, when she returns home after two tours in Vietnam, she is stunned by the lack of welcome she receives. She is spit on at the airport and has trouble finding a cab to take her home. Once there, she learns that her parents are so ashamed of her service that they lied to their country club friends about it. She realizes quickly that Vietnam veterans are not respected; there is no thank-you for their service. The only way to survive is to “disappear” into the landscape and not talk about the war.

How did this impact a generation of Americans? What would it feel like to have served your country in wartime only to be spit upon when you came home? How did this treatment affect the veterans in both the long and short term? How did it affect Frankie? Can you understand her trauma?

6. Explore and discuss the theme of honor in the novel as it relates to Frankie's decisions about the war, about her life after the war, and about Jamie and Rye. What is her moral code? Other nurses tell Frankie that in Vietnam, "men lie and they die." How does this statement reflect the events of the novel?

7. "There were no women in Vietnam." When Frankie returns stateside, she encounters people who refuse to take her service and her experiences seriously and ignore her requests for help. Today, women continue to fight for their health rights against a medical system that fails to actively listen and address women's health concerns. Have you ever felt dismissed by a doctor or a hospital when discussing your health? Do you think gender plays a role in how doctors treat their patients?

8. Clearly, Frankie suffers from PTSD after the war. At that time, there was very little understanding of the effects of PTSD, and both the military and the medical community dismissed the notion that a woman could suffer from the effects of war. Frankie herself believes that she "wasn't in combat." Was she? How do you define being in combat?

9. Over the years, Frankie is more and more affected by her PTSD, although she has no way to understand it and no one to help her deal with it. Her symptoms make her feel more alone, more of a failure. But she tries valiantly to "soldier on." It isn't until her miscarriage and Rye's return from the Hanoi Hilton that she really begins to spiral out of control. This is when her mother gives her drugs to "take the edge off." These highly addictive drugs were advertised and prescribed to women as "Mother's Little Helpers."

Why do you think such ads existed? What purpose did they serve? How did you feel about Frankie's coping behavior? Was there ever a time in your life when you felt so alone and helpless that you didn't know what to do? How did Frankie's mental and emotional health journey make you feel?

10. The stigma of mental illness remains prevalent today, and many people would rather suffer in silence than seek help. What do you do to maintain your mental and emotional health? Do you have a supportive group of family and friends to turn to in times of crisis?

11. About her time at war and her understanding of it, Frankie writes: "It's hard to see clearly when the world is angry and divided and you're being lied to." This sentiment applies to many eras throughout human history, including our own. What lessons can we learn from the Vietnam era? Why do you think the world is so polarized now? How much difference does truth make, and consensus, and community? The end of the war was the beginning of healing for America in the time of the novel. What would begin to heal America today? How can individuals make a difference?

12. What do you think was Frankie's darkest moment in the book? What do you think "broke" Frankie? Was it her service and the horrors she witnessed? Was it PTSD? The miscarriage? Or was it breaking her own moral code --- having an affair with a married man? What should Frankie have done when she

learned that Rye was alive? Did you see his betrayal coming? Should Frankie have seen it? What were the clues she missed? Do you believe Rye loved her?

13. In the novel, Frankie goes from sheltered California girl to hardened combat veteran to woman at peace with herself and the world. Her peace is hard-won and continually fought for. In the end, what was it that healed her? Was it friendship? The creation of The Vietnam Veterans Memorial to honor Vietnam veterans? Therapy? Sobriety? How did you feel about Frankie at the end of the novel? Where do you think she goes after the end of the novel? What does the rest of her life look like?

14. At the end of the book, Frankie realizes that “remembrance mattered.” What does she mean by this? Discuss the history of Vietnam-era veterans --- their service and their treatment upon coming home --- and ask yourself what you have learned from this story. What do we owe to our veterans and their families? How can we truly thank them for their service and their sacrifice?

Author Interview

ELISE COOPER: Why write about Vietnam vets now?

KRISTIN HANNAH: I have wanted to write it for quite some time. It has been on my mind for a long while. I wanted to focus on returning from war. I saw this personally when I was a child. I think for a long time Vietnam was a subject people did not want to read about or talk about. I sought to show what life was like in the Vietnam hospitals with its horror, difficulty, and camaraderie. On a book tour I was told by both male and female Vietnam vets and their children how this was an unspoken trauma in their family for over fifty years. If the book helps in some small way this makes me happy.

EC: The female lead, Frankie, a Vietnam vet, seems to have the same journey as many vets who come home and feel misunderstood. Agree?

KH: It is a sad truth that we have often failed our veterans upon their return in how we care for them. This has been my soapbox for a while. If we as a country are going to ask people to put themselves in harm's way for us it really behooves us to care for them fully when they come home. This is especially true of female veterans who are often forgotten in this equation.

EC: Your earlier book, *Home Front*, was similar but focused on a war on terror vet?

KH: My passion for wanting to focus on returning veterans led me to write *Home Front*. This was the beginning of my rearing up to write this book, *The Women*. By speaking with a Blackhawk pilot who deployed, Teresa Burgess, a warrant officer, helped me to find authenticity. She also helped me to understand when women are considered in combat and when they are not. This idea that someone can be a Blackhawk pilot rescuing soldiers in a hot landing zone and not be considered in combat just stayed with me. One of the things the Vietnam nurses heard when they came home and tried to get help for their emotional trauma, "well you were not in combat so why would you have any issues."

EC: Your dedication in *The Women* was very powerful. Do you want to explain it?

KH: It summarizes the book. It is my discovery of why I wrote this story. It was shocking to see that even the male Vietnam vets brushed off what nurses went through. The women were continually confronted with their invisibility and lack of remembrance for their service even by the VA and those who should have known better. Women have served as nurses in wars for ages. It was weird to me how consistently they were overlooked. They have been marginalized or forgotten.

EC: You do explain that the Vietnam veterans, unlike other vets, were treated horrifically, which included being called baby killers, being flipped off, and spat upon. Why put it in?

KH: This is why I wanted to write about the Vietnam era. As a child I remember how they were treated when they came home. My best friend's father was shot down and I wore his POW bracelet for decades. This stayed with me. I always wanted to write about this terrible and dark period of American history because it so important for healing, individually and as a nation. We need to recognize and

remember their service. I think in many instances they lived in the shadows about what they went through.

EC: You also delve into PTSD?

KH: Remember this is a time when there was no help for PTSD for the men either. This is the beginning of the treatment and the understanding of it. The male vets faced daunting challenges to getting help as well, especially in the late 1960s. These vets came home to a toxic American reaction to their service. I do not think it can be overstated about how it affected their healing and wanting to get help. This was entirely new. The WWII vets came home to ticker tape parades of gratitude and honor, while the Vietnam vets, both male and female, came home to horror.

EC: Do you think PTSD played a huge role in the book?

KH: In my first draft I did not include it because I wrote about it before in *Home Front* and *The Great Alone*, the dark side of PTSD. But the truth is, in reading about the Vietnam era vets it felt wrong not to talk about this journey of theirs including emotional trauma, flashbacks, nightmares, and responses they did not understand. There was this layer of shame and silence that overlayed their service. I had to have Frankie experience what so many of her sister and male counterparts experienced.

EC: Do you think wars now and in the past helped women who served be more empowered, many breaking the glass ceiling?

KH: I agree. I met a woman who was a nurse over there, became a lawyer, and is now a judge in Southern California. She said that one of the things learned after being a nurse in Vietnam is that “we can do anything.” I thought how true and powerful. The women who I met have a wide range of careers. The 1960s was a time when women’s roles were much more prescribed, yet these women broke out of it and realized their own strength and power. Women should be able to do anything they want.

EC: How would you describe Frankie?

KH: I created Frankie to be a woman of her time, someone coming of age in the 50s and 60s. She realized her own strength but became broken by her Vietnam experience. Because of her lack of healing, she makes choices that destroy her. She must fight with her girlfriends at her side as well as her own self to become the best version of herself. She has learned from her mistakes, a survivor. At times very competent, angry, fragile, anxious, and unhinged. She is very smart, honest, and compassionate. Not necessary all these things all at once, a before and after. When she came home to stateside after the war, she is fighting between the woman she was raised to be and the woman the Vietnam War turned her into. It takes her a long time to accept this new version of herself. She had to forge an unfamiliar and sometimes an unsupported path.

EC: What about the friends Ethel and Barb?

KH: Barb was the rebel rouser. They both are loyal and helped each other and Frankie. They are strong and believed in each other. This is a presentation of female camaraderie during war. One thing I always

heard is that war can be the best of times and the worst of times simultaneously. The best of times is the friendships they made, and they felt they did something that mattered. Barb, Ethel, and Frankie were literally saving lives. This all comes together that created powerful bonds.

EC: You have a recurring theme in all your books?

KH: Yes, female friendship is something I care deeply about. It is important to me that Frankie was healed by herself but also with her girlfriends. They saved her.

EC: What about Frankie's relationship with her father?

KH: I found in my research how often these women who served felt unsupported by their own families, both on leaving and on returning. The father was part of the greatest generation who taught Frankie to be proud of her family's military service. He was proud when his son went off to war, but embarrassed and ashamed when his daughter did the same thing. I think many women in Vietnam did not have the support of their own families.

EC: Frankie's love interests: Jamie and Rye?

KH: Rye was Frankie's brother's best friend. Over the course of her in country and at home life she falls in love several times. Some of these love stories prove to be helpful and some are difficult.

EC: The way Jamie was described I thought of Robert Redford in the movie *The Way We Were*—do you agree?

KH: Me too. I said in the book that he looked like Robert Redford in the movie *This Property Is Condemned*.

EC: Did the movie or TV show *MASH* come into your mind?

KH: I mention it in the book because it came out in 1972/73. I grew up watching it. It took me awhile to figure out what war were they talking about. I was astounded by those who said, "there were no women in Vietnam," considering *MASH* was on. Women have served as nurses throughout wars. How is it that these women were completely forgotten, even by the people who ought to know better.

EC: The emphasis in the book is that those women who served in Vietnam were forgotten?

KH: And they were not thought about. I saw this cartoon where someone pulled a military uniform out of the attic, and someone asked when did your grandfather serve. They responded, "it was my grandmother." It is so indicative to me that people automatically think soldiers are just male. There were over 10,000 women serving in Vietnam.

EC: Is *The Nightingale* still going to be made into a movie?

KH: It got stalled for a couple of years because of the pandemic and then got tripped up because of the writer's strike and the actor's strike. I think we are finally on track to film in 2024, fingers crossed.

EC: Do you have any control over your books being made into movies?

KH: Control is not a word I would use. For *The Nightingale* they have been good about keeping me involved that includes me reading the script and giving input. This is as much as I can hope for as a novelist since I do not want to do the heavy lifting. So, I must give up control to the people who hopefully know what they are doing.

EC: Is this book, *The Women*, going to be made into a movie?

KH: Warner Bros. has picked it up and they want to do a big screen. I do not have control, but I do have input. I feel very much I am a part of the team, and this is a great feeling.

EC: Next book?

KH: Right now, I am thinking about some things.

EC: THANK YOU!

Author Biography

Kristin Hannah is the award-winning and bestselling author of more than 20 novels including the international blockbuster, *The Nightingale*, which was named Goodreads Best Historical fiction novel for 2015 and won the coveted People's Choice award for best fiction in the same year. Additionally, it was a selection of the Reese Witherspoon Book Club in 2023. It was named a Best Book of the Year by Amazon, iTunes, BuzzFeed, the Wall Street Journal, Paste, and The Week. In 2018, *The Great Alone* became an instant New York Times #1 bestseller and was named the Best Historical Novel of the Year by Goodreads.

The Four Winds was published in February of 2021 and immediately hit #1 on the New York Times, Wall Street Journal, USA Today, and Indie bookstores' bestseller lists. Additionally, it was selected as a book club pick by the both Today Show and the Book Of the Month club, which named it the best book of 2021.

The Nightingale is currently in production at Tri Star, with Dakota and Elle Fanning set to star. Tri Star has also optioned *The Great Alone* and it is in development. *Firefly Lane*, her beloved novel about two best friends, was the #1 Netflix series around the world, in the week it came out. The popular tv show stars Katherine Heigl and Sarah Chalke and Season Two is currently set to conclude the series on April 27, 2023.

A former attorney, Kristin lives in the Pacific Northwest.

Reviews

Despite fancying myself a historical fiction aficionado, “The Women” was my first taste of author Kristin Hannah. My freshly-bought copy of Hannah’s 2015 novel “The Nightingale” suggests that it will not be my last.

“The Women” is a historical fiction novel set against the backdrop of the Vietnam War. It follows military nurse Frances “Frankie” McGrath as she leaves her illustrious family on Coronado Island, California, and enters the muddy trenches — and even muddier aftermath — of the war. Frankie enlists as a military nurse for two reasons: to join her brother already on the ground and to finally earn her parents’ approval. Suffice to say, that romanticized patriotism does not nearly prepare her for the mortar attacks and napalm wounds that would become her new normal. Frankie begins her first tour in standard-issue pumps that are quickly replaced by combat boots and returns a different woman to a country she can no longer recognize. She is forced to reconcile the war she once believed in with the contentious events that she experienced firsthand. Moreover, she must learn to hide her own scars to rejoin a society that insists “there were no women in Vietnam.”

If I could give the first half of “The Women” a rating, it would be nothing short of phenomenal. Hannah has a way with prose that makes devastation tangible and hope beautifully aching. Watching Frankie grow from a naive socialite to a relied-upon trauma nurse is empowering enough that I (briefly) reconsidered pre-med. Hannah’s delicately crafted moments of female friendship and intimate glimpses into the bonds wrought by grief conjure a striking image of wartime camaraderie. I will admit, I initially screamed cliché when I read the novel’s pseudo-mantra “women can be heroes too,” but Hannah goes on to capture it in the most viscerally honest way.

The second half of the novel is equally well-written and rife with relevant, heart-wrenching details. However, the plot does lose me in a few places. Namely, the romance. I can’t believe I am saying this (especially as a committed romance defender), but I think the romantic relationships are slightly overplayed. There are just so many complex dynamics of character development and friendship that could be prioritized instead. That said, I do feel Hannah does a tremendous job using romance as a vessel to address other crises of the time. Her consideration of substance abuse and female subjugation are pressing conversations. The time she spends delving into Frankie’s psychological challenges and her coming-of-age in a tumultuous social climate are also well-developed.

Overall, I would definitely recommend “The Women” to any historical fiction lover. That is with one disclaimer: this is NOT a beach read. The subject is complex, the topics are heavy, and silver linings are few and far between. Nonetheless, the novel’s main purpose, to remind us that women should and must be honored for the sacrifices they make, is a sentiment that must be amplified. “The Women” reminds us that far too many voices go forgotten, and unearthing those stories is vital to realizing the power of our past, present, and future.

Read-Alikes

Absolution by Alice McDermott

A riveting account of women's lives on the margins of the Vietnam War, from the renowned winner of the National Book Award.

The Great Divide by Cristina Henriquez

A novel about the construction of the Panama Canal, following the intersecting lives of the local families fighting to protect their homeland, the West Indian laborers recruited to dig the waterway, and the white Americans who gained profit and glory for themselves.